
About this extract

This is a nine page extract from "Including students with Autism Spectrum Disorder in the primary classroom: a teacher's guide", a twenty-eight page booklet I wrote in 2019 as part of my Master of Education at the University of New South Wales.

The pages here are the cover and pages 3, 8, 9, 12, 15, 18, 19 and 21. Because they are not consecutive, a few of them begin or end part way through a section. The full booklet reads continuously and is referenced throughout.

A note on the language. This was written in 2019 and uses the clinical terms that were standard then. I would write it differently now, closer to the way autistic people describe themselves. The classroom strategies still hold.

If the full booklet would be useful to you, please write to me at ngocbui.edpsy@gmail.com.

Ngoc Bui

Hanoi, Vietnam



BOOKLET

Including
students with
Autism
Spectrum
Disorder
in the primary
classroom:
A
teacher's
guide

29th April 2019

Ngoc Anh Bui

University of New South Wales

A. General information

Highlights:

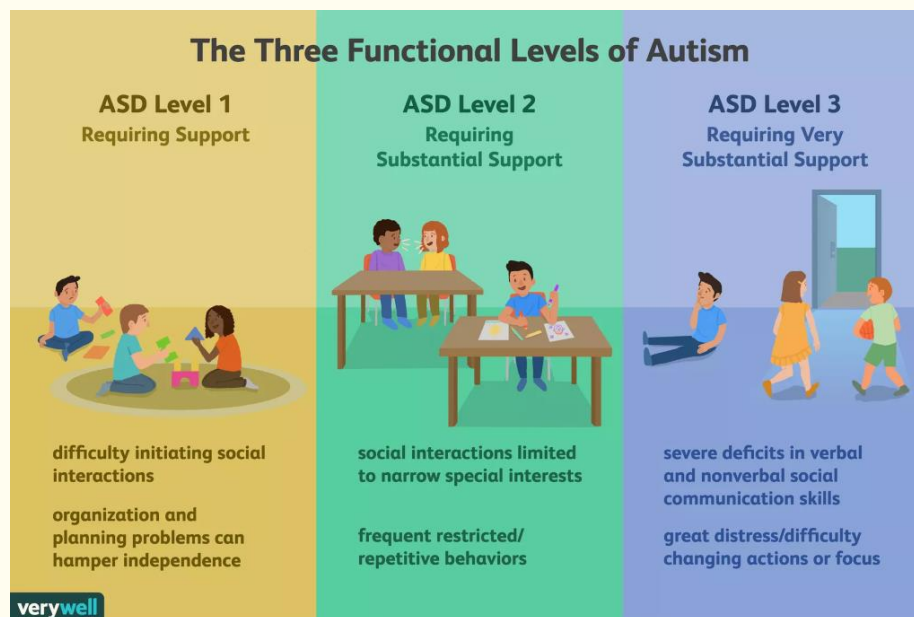
- *Students with ASD often have difficulty in communication, forming friendships and behaving appropriately in social situations.*
- *Sensory issues and cognitive impairments make it hard for them to focus in class, stay on tasks and take part in daily activities.*

What is Autism?

- Autism is a neurodevelopmental disorder, characterised by remarkable deficits in social communication and unusually restricted, repetitive behaviour and interests. ¹Autism is **NOT** an intellectual disability. ²
- In 2013, Asperger's syndrome, Pervasive Developmental Disorders NOS (PDDNOS), Rett Syndrome were collapsed into a single diagnosis of Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD). For that reason, the popular term “**Asperger's syndrome**” is **no longer an official diagnosis**. ³
- ASD is categorised into three levels of severity that require respective levels of support ⁴ as

shown in

Figure 1.



Early Intervention (0-2)	Preschool (3-5)	Elementary (6-11)	Middle (12-14)	High (15-22)
No studies	Social	Social		No studies
	Communication	Communication	Communication	
		Joint Attention		

Figure 2

6 phases of PECS acquisition:

Phase 1: Teach the physically assisted exchange

Phase 2: Expand spontaneity

Phase 3: Simultaneous discrimination of pictures

Phase 4: Build sentence structure

Phase 5: Respond to “What do you want?”

Phase 6: Comment in response to a question



Figure 3

2. Social stories

- Social stories (or Social narratives) explain social situations, describe socially expected behaviour to students with ASD and help them learn appropriate social responses through social scripts, narratives or stories.

- The stories are usually short and tailored to the student's needs. Social stories are most effective when used daily. However, it is less effective for students with low comprehension skill or non-verbal individuals.

Outcomes of Social Stories by age are shown in Figure 4.

Early Intervention (0-2)	Preschool (3-5)	Elementary (6-11)	Middle (12-14)	High (15-22)
No studies	Social	Social	Social	
	Communication	Communication		
	Joint Attention	Joint Attention		
	Behavior	Behavior	Behavior	Behavior
		School-Readiness		
	Play	Play		
	Adaptive	Adaptive		
	Academic	Academic		

Figure 4

Step 1: Identify the social situation that needs to be addressed

Step 2: Define the target skill or behaviour

Step 3: Write a social story that:

- Is easy for the student to understand
- Is based on the student's characteristics and suitable for his or her age
- Includes photos or illustrations
- Is written in first person

Step 4: Introduce the story to the student

- Read the story to the student
- Explain and review key concepts
- Make the student read the story and insert it into his or her daily routine

3. Video modelling

Students with ASD are often strong visual learners .²⁸ You can take advantage of these strengths by teaching academic skills through visual approaches. Visual cues direct students' attention to the learning tasks, improve social interaction and reduce repetitive behaviour. In order to be effective, visual strategies should be tailored to the learner's interests and needs.²⁹ For example, if the student is interested in airplanes, you can incorporate this interest into teaching literacy skill as shown in Figure 7.

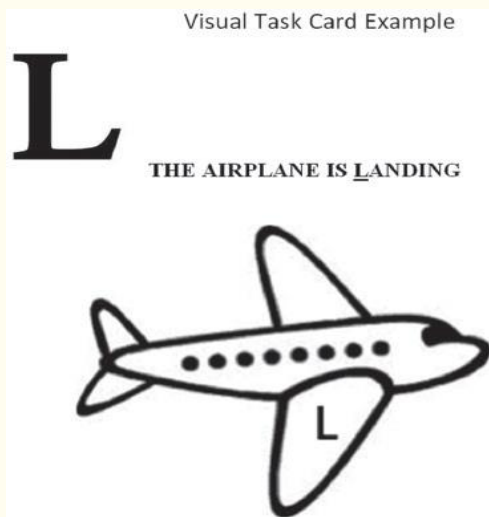


Figure 7

Example of a social story

Social Story Example: Dogs

My name is Mike.



I love dogs.
I love to talk about dogs.



Sometimes I talk about dogs in the classroom while the teacher is talking.



The kids are trying to listen to the teacher.



I shouldn't talk while the teacher is talking.



There are good places for me to talk about dogs.

I can talk about dogs at lunch, on the playground, or on the bus.



The classroom is not a good place to talk about dogs.

I will listen when the teacher is talking.



By listening, I will make my teacher and peers happy.



Organising tasks using the Premack principle

According to the Premack principle, a non-desired task is likely to be engaged in when followed by a preferred task. Students with ASD tend to have restricted interests, and this principle will help to take advantage of that to motivate the students.³²

Tips: you can deliver a non-preferred task before a preferred task, alternate between non-preferred and preferred tasks in the schedule (Figure 11).

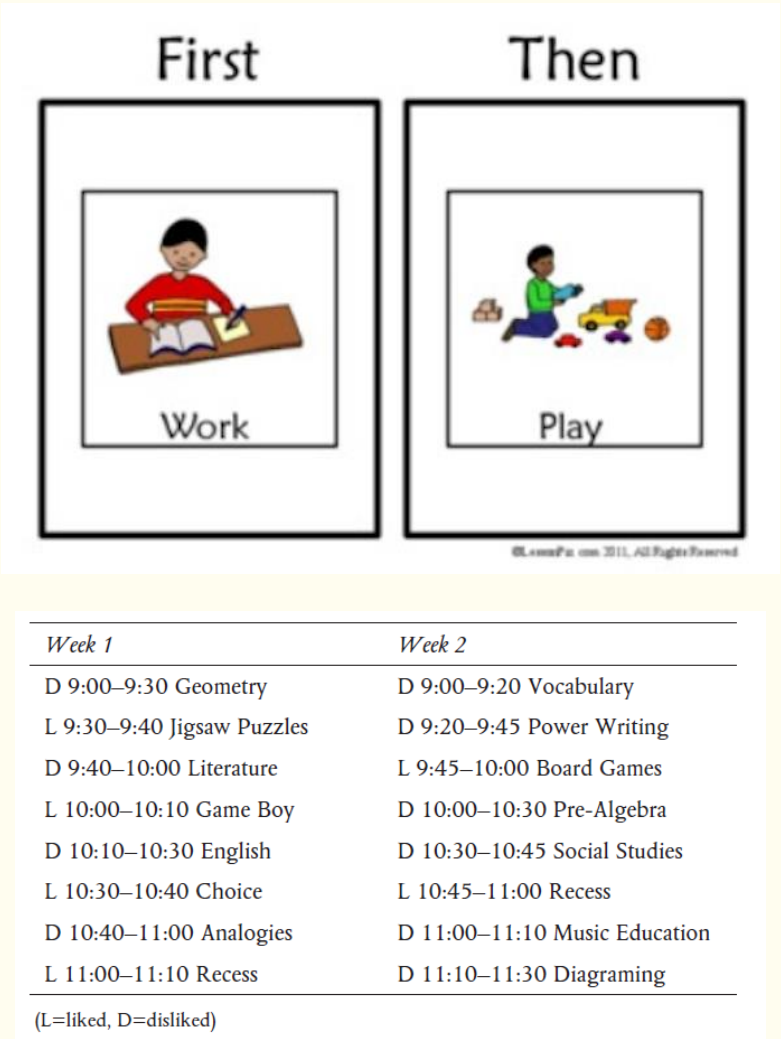


Figure 11

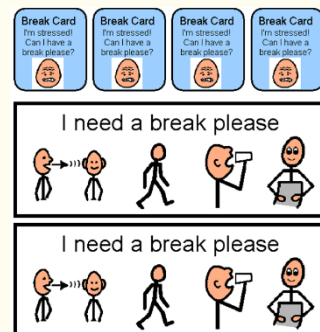
Deliver tasks according to energy levels

- Keep the classroom as simple and neat as you can, otherwise a classroom with cluttered walls would be visually distracting to students with ASD.⁴⁹
- If artworks and props must be stored in the classroom, try to organise them in a way that reduces clutter and visual overload in students' learning space.⁵⁰



Calm zone

- To reduce anxiety and stress throughout the school day, some students with ASD may need breaks and some time in a quiet corner.⁵¹
- Provide some visual cue cards to help students request a break.⁵²
- Break duration should be short (up to 5 minutes).⁵³
- The calm zone shouldn't be used as a "time-out" area, otherwise it will lose its function as a place for self-calming.⁵⁴

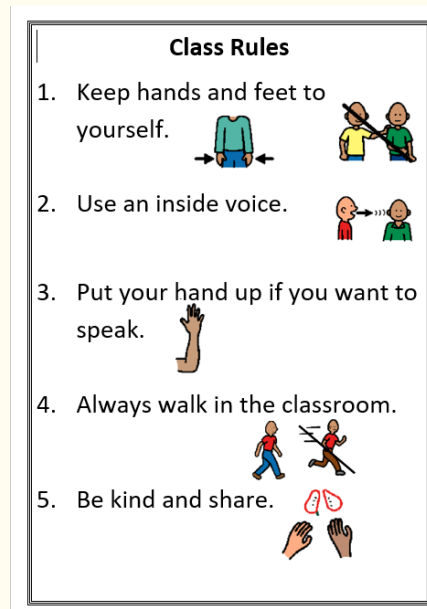


3. Instructional design

Classroom schedules and rules

Predictability is the key as students with ASD are often preoccupied with rules and routines.⁵⁵ You can accommodate this by some simple strategies:

- Post class schedule in the walls and give students a copy if possible.
- Give students reminders of homework, tests and other deadlines.⁵⁶
- Clearly point out what are expected behaviours in the classroom.
- Use visual cues to help students navigate the school day and organize their stuff.



Language

Since students with ASD take figurative language very literally⁵⁷, you should:

- Avoid using idioms, sarcasm and metaphors such as “keep my fingers crossed”,⁵⁸
- Use plain and direct language when communicating with students. For example, just say “quit” or “stop” instead of “call it a day.”



Allow wait time

The setup principle.

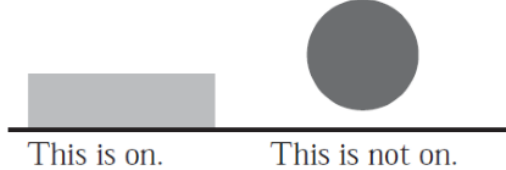
Following the setup principle	Not following the setup principle
 This is on. This is not on.	 This is on. This is not on.

Figure 12

The left pair has two same items. The right pair has different items that can lead to different interpretations. For example, in the right pair, a student might think “on” is rectangle and “not on” means round, grey, or circle. Making two items with the same features as the right pair will provide **explicit associations** and **eliminate irrelevant interpretations** for students with ASD. ⁶⁶

4. Fostering friendships

Given the difficulties that students with ASD experience in social interactions and peer relationship, teachers should help these students develop friendships through the following strategies:

- Peer-mediated interventions: this is also an EBP that enhances social involvement and communicative behaviours of children with ASD. Peer-mediated interventions can include peer tutoring, peer modelling and peer interaction. ⁶⁷
- Highlight the strengths of students with ASD to peers so that typically developing peers can appreciate their friends with ASD more.
- Give students with ASD some manageable class responsibilities to create more chances for peer interactions. ⁶⁸
- Fade prompts and assistance to allow more natural interactions. ⁶⁹

D. Useful resources